

Career Development Reference Guide

Taking Ownership of Your Professional Growth

YOUR GROWTH IS YOUR RESPONSIBILITY

Career development is not something that happens to you. It is something you build intentionally. This guide is a tool you can return to at any stage of your journey to assess where you are, set your direction, and identify your next step.

YOUR INDIVIDUAL DEVELOPMENT PLAN (IDP)

Your IDP is your personal career roadmap. It belongs to you. Return to it regularly, update it as you grow, and let it guide your next move.

Career Vision	Where do you want to be in 2 to 5 years?
Current Strengths	What skills and qualities do you bring right now?
Growth Areas	What skills or knowledge do you need to develop?
Action Steps	What specific steps will you take in the next 90 days?
Resources Needed	Training, mentors, books, certifications, or experiences.
Progress Check	Set a date to review and update your plan.

WRITING A SMART GOAL

Specific	Clearly state what you want to achieve.
Measurable	Define how you will know you have achieved it.
Achievable	Make sure it is realistic given your current situation.
Relevant	Connect it to your longer-term career vision.
Time-Bound	Set a target date or deadline.

BUILDING SKILLS ON ANY BUDGET

- Free online learning: Coursera (audit option), LinkedIn Learning, Google Career Certificates.
- On-the-job: Volunteer for projects outside your current role.
- Mentorship: Identify someone whose career you admire and ask one specific question.
- Reading: Follow one industry voice or publication consistently.
- Community: Join a professional association or local networking group.

OVERCOMING COMMON BARRIERS

"I don't have time."	One hour per week is 52 hours of growth per year. Schedule it.
"I don't know where to start."	Start with one question: Where do I want to be in two years? Write the answer down.
"There are no opportunities here."	Visibility creates opportunities. Volunteer, take initiative, and build your reputation.
"I'm afraid of failing."	Every challenge you take on builds capability. The only guaranteed failure is staying still.

"Invest in yourself. It's the best investment you will ever make."

— Warren Buffett